

Action Directives – User Guide

Revision: 1 **Last modified:** 2026-07-14T21:50:00Z **Authority:** constitution §11.4.140 (action-prefix system) + §11.4.202 (reporting directives) **Maintainer:** constitution submodule **Scope:** for anyone *using* the directives. If you are wiring them into a project, read [ADMIN_MANUAL.md](#) instead.

Companion documents: [REFERENCE.md](#) · [QUICKSTART_REPORT.md](#) · [QUICKSTART_INSTALL.md](#)

. The idea in one sentence

Start a prompt with a registered UPPERCASE token and that token is replaced by a full, pre-agreed instruction — so you type five characters instead of a paragraph, and the agent behaves the same way every time.

BUG: subtitles render one frame late on the secondary display

...is executed as *"REPORT DIRECTIVE — BUG (§11.4.202). The remainder of this prompt is a REPORT of a product DEFECT... create it through the project's reporting engine... never merely acknowledged, never silently dropped..."* followed by your actual text.

. The five directives

Directive	Reach for it when	What the agent then does
BUG	Something is broken — a regression, a defect, user-visible wrong behaviour.	Creates a fully-populated Type=Bug workable item (Status <code>Queued</code> , stable ticket id, structured description), regenerates every derived document from the DB, pushes to every configured external tracker, reports the ticket id back — then, if actionable now, investigates it under systematic-debugging (root cause before any fix).
TASK	Internal workstream — a refactor, a doc, infra, a gate, an audit, a chore.	Same pipeline, Type=Task (fixed).
ISSUE	Anything trackable and you have not decided what it is.	Classifies it into the closed set <code>{Bug Feature Task}</code> from the report's own content. If the content does not determine the type it asks you before creating anything. Then the same create + sync + push pipeline.
BACK-GROUND	Work that should proceed in parallel with the main stream and must never be lost.	Records the request in the durable background queue immediately (id + timestamp + status + blocker), then runs it subagent-driven in parallel. If it cannot run now it stays QUEUED with its blocker recorded and is re-attempted at the next opportunity — including in a fresh session. It never interrupts the main stream, and it is never silently dropped.
REMINDER	You are re-surfacing earlier work whose status you are unsure of .	Does not assume it is done or not done. First verifies the actual status from captured evidence (git state, the task list, the background queue, test artifacts, the workable-items DB). Then acts on the delta: report the proof if genuinely complete, resume from the exact point if partial, start it now if not started, or surface the block. It always produces a status verdict.

ISSUE is a channel, not a type. There is no "Issue" type — every item is a `Bug`, a `Feature`, or a `Task`.

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. How to invoke – six equivalent forms

All six do exactly the same thing. Use whichever you like.

<code>BUG: subtitles are one frame late</code>	← 6. single-colon (what most people type)
<code>BUG :: subtitles are one frame late</code>	← 1. bare <code>::</code>
<code>DEFAULT::BUG :: subtitles are one frame late</code>	← 2. namespaced <code>::</code>
<code>BUG ---> subtitles are one frame late</code>	← 5. arrow
<code>/DEFAULT::BUG subtitles are one frame late</code>	← 4. namespaced slash
<code>/bug subtitles are one frame late</code>	← 3. bare slash – SEE §5, /
<code>bug COLLIDES</code>	

The rules, in short:

- **Only the first non-blank line counts.** A token in the middle of a paragraph never triggers.
- **UPPERCASE only.** `bug: ...` is ordinary text.
- **Spacing is exact.** `::` and `--->` need one space on each side; `NAME:` needs the colon tight against the name and one space after it. This is what keeps `std::vector`, YAML `key: value`, and URLs from ever triggering.
- **You can stack them.** `BACKGROUND :: BUG: the HDMI sink drops to stereo` applies the outer directive, then the inner one, then the task.

Worked examples

TASK: bump the pandoc pin to 3.2 and regenerate the exports

ISSUE: playback stutters on 4K HDR after ~40 minutes – happens on both boxes

BACKGROUND ---> audit every gate for a paired mutation and file what is missing

REMINDER: the OTA signing-key rotation we scheduled last week

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. Escaping – talking about a directive without firing it

Put a single backslash in front. The backslash is stripped and nothing expands:

\BUG: this is an example of the syntax, do not open a ticket
\BACKGROUND likewise

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. The collision: `/bug` vs `/helix:bug` vs `/default-bug`

Claude Code ships its **own built-in** `/bug` (report a bug to Anthropic). The registry declares that collision as data (`slash_conflicts: [bug]`), and the system respects it — **the plugin never silently shadows a host command.**

You type	What runs
<code>/bug audio is silent</code>	Claude Code's built-in. Not the directive.
<code>/helix:bug audio is silent</code>	The directive. Plugin namespacing is always unambiguous.
<code>/default-bug audio is silent</code>	The directive. The collision-free alias — works on every agent.
<code>BUG: audio is silent</code>	The directive. No host command can touch this form.
<code>BUG :: audio is silent /</code> <code>BUG ---> audio is silent</code>	The directive.

So: for `BUG` , use `BUG:` (simplest) or `/helix:bug` / `/default-bug` .

The other four directives have **no** declared collision, so their bare slash forms work directly: `/task ...` , `/issue ...` , `/background ...` , `/reminder ...` — and `/helix:task` / `/default-task` remain available if your host ever adds a colliding command.

. What happens if you type a token that is not registered

The system **never invents an expansion** and **never silently drops your prompt**.

You type	What happens
<code>BUGG :: audio is silent</code> (typo, <code>::</code> form)	You are asked which registered directive you meant — with the closest name suggested.
<code>/deploy the new image</code> (unregistered slash)	Same: asked, never guessed.
<code>NOTE: remember to re-flash D4</code> (unregistered single-colon)	Nothing happens — it is treated as an ordinary sentence. This is deliberate: <code>NOTE: / TODO: / WARNING: / FIXME:</code> are normal English, and questioning every one of them would be intolerable.

. Sub-system shortcuts

An UPPERCASE token that is not a directive but *is* an incorporated sub-system or submodule expands to that sub-system's working context (repository, org, where it is checked out, plus the rules for working on it — treat it as an equal part of the codebase, keep it decoupled, fetch first, never force-push):

```
HXQA :: add a Challenge bank entry for the subtitle oracle
HELIXOTA ---> investigate the delta-update failure on the 1.2.1 image
```

Tokens come from the curated catalogue (`HXOTA` , `HXQA` , `HXCODE` , `HXAGENT` , `HXLLM` , `HXMEM` , `HXSPEC` , `HXTRACK` , `LLMSVERIFIER` , `CTOOLKIT` , ...) **and** from your own project's submodules, discovered automatically from `.gitmodules` — a newly-added submodule works with no configuration.

If a token is ambiguous (two sub-systems), it is **dropped** and you are asked. A registered directive always wins over a sub-system of the same name.

. How to see what is registered

every registered action, one per line

```
bash -c '. constitution/scripts/action_prefix_lib.sh && apx_list_actions'
```

what one directive actually expands to

```
bash -c '. constitution/scripts/action_prefix_lib.sh && apx_lookup_expansion BUG'
```

dry-run the whole expander on a prompt (JSON: verdict / action / expansion / emitted)

```
bash -c '. constitution/scripts/action_prefix_lib.sh && apx_expand_prompt "BUG: audio is silent"
```

Or just read the source of truth — `constitution/actions/registry.yaml` — and the generated command inventory,

`constitution/plugins/helix/README.md` .

In Claude Code, `/helix:` then Tab lists every command the plugin exposes.

. If a directive does not seem to fire

1. Is it on the **first non-blank line**? A directive in the middle of a prompt never fires.
2. Is it **UPPERCASE**?
3. Is the **spacing exact**? `::` (spaces both sides), `NAME:` (no space before the colon, one after), `--->` (spaces both sides).
4. Did you use a **bare** `/name` **that collides** with a host command (`/bug`)? Use `/helix:bug` or `/default-bug` (§5).
5. Still nothing? The wiring may not be installed in this project — hand [ADMIN_MANUAL.md](#) to whoever set it up, or run the one-line installer in [QUICKSTART_INSTALL.md](#).